

Sales tanked nearly 25 percent in a year, and the company's stock plunged. Johnson lost his job after just seventeen months and JCPenney quickly brought back ~~deceptive pricing practices~~ sales and coupons. "We did not realize how deep some of the customers were into [coupons]," an executive said at the time. Johnson later agreed: "Coupons were a drug." And shoppers were addicted.

A former JCPenney employee said of the season: "I can't tell you how many people complained about not having coupons anymore. They wanted to see the high prices getting lower at the register instead of just seeing a lower price. I never understood it."

That's because we want to believe we are getting more value for less money. Getting a deal may make you feel smart, like you've outwitted capitalism and you've gotta tell your friends all about it. In reality, thanks in part to JCPenney, stores know this. And their sales, discounts, and coupons are not for your benefit. A lot of them aren't even real.

Consumers' Checkbook,⁶ a nonprofit consumer-advocacy publication, tracked product prices at two dozen major retailers for over six months. Researchers found that all but two companies used deceptive sales marketing. Retailers including Amazon, Walmart, JCPenney, and more had products "on sale" all thirty-three weeks or almost every week. This study expanded on studies they performed in 2015 and 2018. Every year shows deceptive sale pricing becoming more widespread across products and retailers.

Kohls has the audacity to say⁷ in their terms and conditions that they most likely never sold their sale items at their "original" price. They state: "The 'Regular' or 'Original' price of an item is the former or future offered price for the item or a comparable item by Kohl's or another retailer. Actual sales may not have been made at the 'Regular' or 'Original' prices."

These special-but-not-really discounts, holiday sales, and annual/semiannual/biannual/second-weekend-of-the-month events are designed to make you overvalue products, giving you a sense of urgency and scarcity of product, and discourage you from researching better offers or even better sales at other times of the year. After all, if it's "60 percent off" here, that's a great deal—why compare prices elsewhere?

So, there is no doable action step for this one. Maybe it's an anti-action step. Yes, we love finding a coupon or getting a bulk discount on something we were going to buy anyway, but buying something you "could" or